

The Five Major Schools of Thought in Psychology

Let's dive straight into these.

Structuralism

Structuralism was the first school of thought in psychology. It was founded by Wilhelm Wundt, a German professor, philosopher, and physiologist. Although it was Wundt's work that built the foundation of structuralism, the school of thought was formally established by his student, Edward B. Titchener in the 1890s.

Structuralism gets its name from its objective, which is to explore the structure of the mind. Wundt sought to understand the structure of the mind by using **introspection** as his primary tool. Events or experiences were broken down into the smallest possible elements to be assessed, so the researcher could better understand the contents of consciousness.

(Example)

If this is hard to understand, here's another example. Take a table: To a structuralist, a table isn't a place to work or a surface to put things on. It is wood, metal bars, bolts, and screws.

Though this school of thought pushed the field of psychology forward during its time, it was ultimately critiqued for the subjective nature of **introspection**. Stimulus is rarely perceived the same way from one person to the next.

Functionalism

The American psychologist, historian, and philosopher William James developed the school of **functionalism** in the late 19th/early 20th century, after strong criticism of the structuralist approach. Unlike **structuralism**, which broke experiences down into small elements, the functionalist approach focused on the whole of an experience. Functionalists define a mental state not by what it is made of, but by what it does. A particular mental state depends on its function to be understood.

(Example)

The example of a mousetrap is famously used to explain the functionalist theory. While not all mouse traps are made equally - some are large and elaborate, some are a simple spring hinge on a board - they all serve the same purpose, which is to

kill mice. Regardless of what it is made of, how many parts it possesses, or even the supposed quality of the material, it is a mousetrap if its function is to kill mice.

Psychoanalysis

Psychoanalysis was founded by the Austrian scholar **Sigmund Freud**. It focused on the workings of the unconscious mind to explain human behavior. This school of thought holds that all people have unconscious desires, memories, and thoughts, resulting in repressed emotions. Psychoanalysis aims to make these unconscious elements conscious to find catharsis.

*Deep dive

Freud developed a three-part structure of the human mind. These were the id, ego, and superego. Psychoanalysis maintains that the interaction of these three parts explains personality and human behavior. Freud stressed the importance of the proper development of id, ego, and superego across his five Psychosexual Stages of Development. Unresolved conflicts during any stage of development can cause one to become fixated in that stage, emphasizing or repressing certain behaviors or personality traits.

Behaviorism

Behaviorism was founded by John B. Watson in 1924. It emphasizes experience and one's environment over internal or subconscious forces. Behaviorism believes that human psychology is better understood through a subject's behavior, rather than their personal beliefs or thoughts.

According to this school of thought, behavior is learned through two types of **conditioning**, classical and operant. In classical **conditioning**, an association is forged between two stimuli; a conditioned stimulus, and an unrelated unconditioned stimulus, to create a behavior. A classic (and famous) example of this is Pavlov's dog.

In operant conditioning, behaviors are created or enforced through reward or punishment. Here the association is made between behavior and consequence.

Gestalt Psychology

While some schools of thought emphasized the structure of the mind or the expression of behavior to understand our world and human nature, [Gestalt psychology](#) believed it took both of these things to gain a true understanding of the whole of our world. Indeed, a central tenet of Gestalt psychology is holism, which emphasizes the whole over the sum of its parts. The term Gestalt itself is a German word loosely meaning "configuration". It is the configuration of multiple things that give us true meaning, and this true meaning sits apart from its parts.

Think of your experience of a song. Our minds perceive a song as a meaningful whole. Every song is made up of individual notes; however, it is the configuration of the notes that creates a meaningful experience. Upsetting or altering one small component can result in a completely different experience.

